"As long as tribals do not realise this, such attempts will continue," he adds, adding any such move will deprive tribals of their constitutional rights.

However, former MLA and Dhangar leader Prakash Shendge justifies their demand. "The Dhangars were counted as tribals in the Central Provinces and Berar region. The vernacular 'r' is changed to 'd' in English. It is a problem of language that has deprived the Dhangars of tribal status as they are referred to as Dhangads in the ST list," he claims. Shengde believes established politicians are opposing the demand in the guise of tribal welfare. "If the Dhangars are included in the ST category, assembly seats like Baramati will be reserved for them and the political empires of established politicians will be destroyed," he claims. Baramati is the stronghold of the Pawar family, which is now split into the rival factions of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) led by Sharad Pawar and his nephew and deputy CM Ajit Pawar. Shendge says the Dhangars number 15 million and dominate in around 78 assembly segments.

Activist Dr Sneha Sonkate says pastoralist herders live like tribals and demands that a government resolution (GR) stating that Dhangars and Dhangads are the same be issued. She points to how despite their numbers, the Dhangars have just one MLA in Maharashtra, as against 105 Maratha ones. "Reservation is meant to do away with social injustice," stresses Sonkate. Writer and activist Sanjay Sonwani cites the *Encyclopedia of Scheduled Tribes* by P.K. Mohanty to note that the condition of the Dhangars is 'worse than Adivasis'. He questions how Dhangars could be classified as OBCs and not tribals when traditionally they too were outside the ambit of settled village life. ■



Balbir Sidhu and Gurpreet Kangar, too, are on the vigilance radar, but they are now in the BJP, having quit the Congress after the 2022 assembly poll debacle.

Indeed, the party is yet to regroup after the disaster. The opposition BJP and the ruling AAP have been actively poaching Congress leaders. In fact, the state BJP unit seems a replica of the Congress unit from a couple of years ago. Ex-CM Amarinder Singh has merged his Punjab Lok Congress with the BJP, and former Congress state unit chief Sunil Jakhar now holds the same post in the BJP. AAP, too, has got into the act. For the recent Jalandhar Lok Sabha seat bypoll, AAP poached Congressman Sushil Rinku and ensured his victory. Among AAP's 92 legislators in the Punjab assembly, around 40 have a Congress background, including cabinet minister Brahm Shankar Sharma Jimpa. In fact, AAP has grown in Punjab by eating into the Congress base in urban areas and the Akali votes in rural areas.

PUNJAB CM MANN LOSES NO OPPORTUNITY TO BERATE THE CONGRESS OVER ALLEGED CHARGES OF CORRUPTION AND LINKS WITH THE DRUG MAFIA

As for an alliance with AAP, Congress MPs Ravneet Bittu (Ludhiana), G.S. Aujala (Amritsar), Jasbir Gill (Khadoor Sahib) along with cricketer-turned-neta Navjot Sidhu are pushing for it, whereas Warring, leader of the opposition Partap S. Bajwa and Khaira are dead against it. The naysayers say an alliance will damage the party's recovery in the state and could spur an exodus of the mid-level leadership to AAP by the 2027 election.

There are 13 Lok Sabha seats in Punjab, one in Chandigarh and seven in Delhi, the regions where a Congress-AAP tie-up could ruin the BJP's party. In Punjab, the Congress now has seven MPs and AAP one. In Delhi, all seven are BJP parliamentarians. Chandigarh has the BJP's Kirron Kher as MP.

In Delhi, the politics is simple—an alliance will allow a consolidation of the Muslim votes against the BJP. The Congress leadership is reportedly ready to concede seats in Delhi, but, in Punjab, neither side is willing to concede an inch. The Congress is the principal opposition here. In the 2022 assembly polls, AAP captured a 42 per cent vote share, whereas the Congress took 23 per cent. So, on paper, the INDIA bloc looks formidable.

However, the Congress state unit believes Mann's regime is weakening. On September 25, Bajwa made a sensational claim, saying he is in touch with 32 AAP MLAs and is close to toppling the government. "We can win all 13 LS seats in Punjab. I have told the party leadership...we don't need an AAP alliance for this," says Bajwa.

Even as these contradictions reign, indications are that the leaders of both parties are moving towards a deal. If AAP tamps down on its vigilance activity, many Congress leaders will breathe easy. But then, can such a tenuous alliance yield results for INDIA? ■